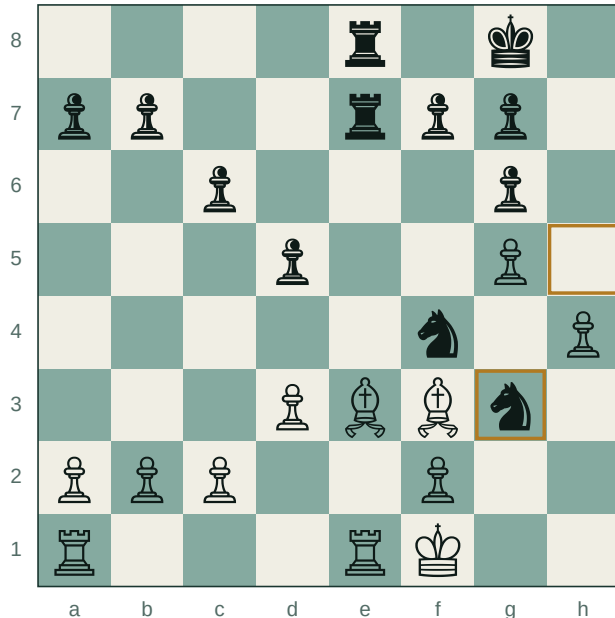


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 24

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 23...Ng3+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24. fxg3 Rxe3 25. Rxe3 Rxe3 26. Kf2 Rxf3+ 27. Kxf3

24.fxg3 The pawn captures the knight on g3. Recorded reply: **24...Rxe3**.

25.Rxe3 The rook captures the rook on e3. Recorded reply: **25...Rxe3**.

26.Kf2 The king moves from f1 to f2. Recorded reply: **26...Rxf3+**.

27.Kxf3 The king captures the rook on f3.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 10 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +2: the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: knight on f4 and knight on g3. Check for tactical protection.